volunteered for the Afghan jihad to al-Rahman. Many of these men, as well as a number of Egyptian volunteers who also fought under him, came to consider Kunar province their home base.[37] Despite the Soviet retreat in 1989, Arabs continued traveling to Afghanistan. For the next several years, many Saudis, along with some Egyptians, continued to join Jamiat al-Dawa al-Quran wal-Sunna in Kunar and to train in camps there.[38] Then in 1991 Gulbuddin Hekmatyar's Hizb-e-Islami invaded Kunar, killing a number of al-Rahman's Arab allies and leading him to flee across the border to the Bajaur tribal agency in Pakistan. He was assassinated not long after.

Prior to launching MDI, Hafiz Saeed and several other founders had studied in Saudi Arabia. They had links to the Saudi ulema as well as to the Islamic University of Medina, where several of the teachers are believed to have contributed to the motivation for forming JuD by promising financial support. When MDI was founded a year later following the union with Zaki-ur Rehman Lakhvi's Ahl-e-Hadith outfit, al-Rahman's JuDQS also supported the nascent organization. Al-Rahman had a base in Bajaur as well, where another Salafi organization, the Jamaat-ul-Mujahideen, also provided early support.[39] MDI established its first training center in Paktia province in Afghanistan in 1987 and soon opened a second in Kunar province, where its cadres trained and fought alongside Jamil al-Rahman as well as the foreign fighters who had joined him there.[40] Like many of the outfits involved in the Afghan jihad, MDI was headquartered in the Pakistani frontier city of Peshawar.

With connections on both sides of the border and to Saudi Arabia, the group helped manage the flow of Arab volunteers, though its primary concern was mobilizing Ahl-e-Hadith Muslims in Pakistan. The Maktab al-Khidmat [Services Bureau], founded by Abdullah Azzam and sponsored by Osama bin Laden, was the major conduit for Arab volunteers traveling to fight in Afghanistan. Azzam was the man most responsible for encouraging Muslims from around the world to participate in the Afghan jihad, and he founded the Maktab al-Khidmat to accommodate the foreign fighters inspired by his call. It streamlined the mobilization process: raising money; recruiting and housing volunteers arriving in Pakistan; deploying them to Afghanistan; and providing them with weapons.[41] The Maktab al-Khidmat is typically considered a precursor to al-Qaeda, though by the time the latter was formed in 1988 bin Laden and Azzam had become estranged.[42] There